From Feedback to Revision: When Do Multi-Agent Roles Look Load-Bearing?

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Abstract

Multi-agent large language model (LLM) systems usually assign roles such as Planner, Executor and Reviewer. We ask when these roles are load-bearing, that is, when removing them lowers performance while call and information budgets stay the same. We test three open-weight models on competition mathematics and two of them on college science. Keeping the agents, topology and budgets unchanged, we delete every role instruction. This deletion largely destroys the intended division of labor, yet first-pass accuracy does not drop. Roles appear useful for repairing rejected answers, clearly for the gemma-4 model and directionally for the gpt-oss model. But this advantage appears only when the role-free team never receives the evaluator's feedback. In an exploratory condition, we give the role-free team the same feedback string. It then recovers from failures more often than the role-structured team (recovery 0.609 against 0.222 for gemma-4 on competition mathematics) and reaches higher final accuracy in every setting. However, the advantage disappears when both teams are credited with the same number of evaluator verdicts, and one robustness check even favors roles. The difference in recovery mainly reflects how often each team submits. The role-structured Reviewer often withholds approval, so its team receives fewer verdicts. In a single exploratory 400-problem run for gemma-4, we submitted the team's answer in every cycle (one pass of the three agents) regardless of the Reviewer, leaving the role prompts unchanged. The role-structured team then recovered as well as the role-free team. We conclude that a clean division of labor is not evidence of adaptability. Role ablations must hold information channels fixed, not only budgets.

Keywords

Multi-agent systems, large language models, role specialization, division of labor, organizational structure, ablation

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1 Introduction

Researchers usually present a multi-agent large language model system as a detailed diagram. It features components like a Planner that decomposes without solving, an Executor that carries out the plan, a Reviewer that critiques rather than re-derives (PER), and arrows for who hands what to whom [21, 37, 43]. This diagram is read as a mechanism that explains where the system's competence comes from and justifies the cost of multiple agents. In practice, however, what runs is simply a set of prompts handed to a language model. The model may honor the intended division of labor, ignore it or satisfy its surface constraints while solving the entire problem in every box. A simple accuracy score cannot distinguish between these scenarios. A pipeline whose agents have quietly collapsed into identical solvers returns the same final score as an organization that works exactly as drawn.

This ambiguity raises a critical question about which phases of the problem-solving process, and under what conditions, genuinely rely on multi-agent organization. A team must first produce an answer and, if that answer is rejected, produce a different one. We ask when the assigned roles are truly load-bearing during these distinct phases. We define a component as load-bearing if removing or altering it reproducibly degrades task performance under matched call and information budgets (§3). Matching the information budget is subtle because feedback reaches each agent through its prompt, and a role ablation inherently rewrites those exact channels. To test this, we hold the topology, actor model (the language model that plays all three agents), retry budget and evaluator fixed, and we vary the organization in both directions: we delete every role instruction and, separately, we enforce the division of labor at the interface, through typed message formats. Deleting the roles largely destroys the intended division of labor (aided by the fact that the role-free prompt asks each agent for its current answer). Yet, consistent with prior role ablations [10, 35], this functional collapse does not degrade first-pass accuracy.

After a rejected first answer, roles do seem to matter. The role-structured team recovers more failed trajectories, runs on a problem whose first answer was rejected, than a role-free baseline team, clearly for the gemma-4 model and directionally for the gpt-oss model. However, this difference is manufactured by uneven information access. The role-structured templates carry the evaluator's verdict (PASS or FAIL) and repair hint (a correction that must not reveal the answer) to every agent. In contrast, the role-free baseline template has no place for feedback, so those agents never see the verdict or the hint. Roles appear load-bearing for repair only when their prompts are the only channel carrying the feedback. When we introduce an exploratory condition where the role-free team also receives the same feedback string, that team actually recovers more failed trajectories than the role-structured team and achieves higher final accuracy across competition mathematics and, for two of the models, college science.

However, when both teams are credited with the same number of evaluator verdicts per problem, the role-free advantage disappears, and one robustness check favors roles. Roles mainly change how



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often the team asks for external feedback, rather than how well it adapts. Specifically, the role-structured Reviewer withholds approval even before any feedback exists and, on competition mathematics, mostly where no clause forbids approval, so the team submits fewer attempts. Against a ground-truth evaluator and a capped budget, a withheld submission is a lost chance to recover. Overriding this Reviewer in a single exploratory 400-problem run for gemma-4, with the role prompts unchanged, raises the role-structured team's recovery to match the role-free team's on the same problems. Enforcing the division of labor at the interface also loosens the gate and raises recovery (resolvably only for the Llama-3.3 model), but 8% to 17% of enforced trajectories never finish, so end-to-end accuracy does not improve. These results show that a clean division of labor does not guarantee that a team acts on corrective information. Evaluating agent organization requires holding information channels fixed alongside budgets.

We summarize our contributions as follows:

(1) An operational definition of load-bearing multi-agent components, applied per phase through a budget-matched design that varies organization in both directions.
(2) Evidence that a role ablation which drops the feedback channel can manufacture an apparent role effect on repair (clearly for gemma-4, directionally for gpt-oss), and that the role-free advantage disappears once the feedback string and the number of verdicts are matched.
(3) An account of what roles do instead: they mainly act as a gate on submission, measured from the logs and tested by removing the gate in one exploratory run.
(4) A measurement point extending a recent separation of reviewer precision from critique uptake [44]: properties resembling good collaboration do not guarantee that corrective information changes the system's next action (§6).

2 Related Work

Roles in organizational models. Organization-centered multi-agent systems give roles a formal existence independent of their occupants. Moise$^+$ separates structural, functional and *deontic* specifications [24]. OperA makes role adoption an explicit social contract [7], and electronic institutions specify norms outside the agents [13], to be regimented (violation made impossible) or sanctioned [19]. An LLM role prompt is the degenerate case: functional and deontic clauses in prose, with nothing to make them bind. Our role-free condition keeps the positions, the communication graph and the turn order, but deletes these clauses. Conversely, our enforced condition regiments the functional part at the interface. In this paper, adaptability means revising an answer across attempts on the same problem, not reorganizing the team [22]. Teamwork models make repairing a failed joint plan a team obligation [41], which a prompt can state but not secure.

Role specialization and role drift. Prompted roles are known to be unreliable. Agents disobey the role specification across annotated traces [4], and *role drift* has a training-time account [3]. Role-label conditioning fails to induce the intended specialization [35], and agents collapse into highly similar rationales [36]. Differentiation can even arise *without* assigned roles [12]. Recent enforcement-side work makes role scope part of the system structure rather than advice in the prompt [15, 40]. While role drift and the decoupling of role quality from task performance are known [3, 44], we measure them under a controlled ablation.

Redundancy and parity. Dylan et al. [10] hold total LLM calls fixed and find an evolved Planner, Executor and Critic team no better than an evolved single agent. Zhang et al. [47] find that many reported multi-agent efficiency gains arise where one agent suffices. This objection is why we report a single-agent reference (§4). On the same premise, Chen et al. [6] prune redundant agents.

Feedback, revision and answer lock-in. Iterative refinement with self-generated or tool feedback [17, 30, 38] and multi-agent debate [9, 29] are standard patterns. Models often repeat earlier outputs under exact verifier feedback [25]. Under self-reflection, this failure is called Degeneration-of-Thought [29], and belief entrenchment is studied directly [33]. Huang et al. [23] report that self-correction degrades accuracy only in the *intrinsic* setting, where the model judges its own answer, and improves it when the correct label serves as a stopping rule [see also 27, 39]. Our loop is gated by such an oracle (an evaluator that knows the correct answer), where more attempts buy more coverage, the share of problems solved by at least one attempt [1]. This is the regime in which the role-structured team's restraint costs it. Closest to our lever, Chen et al. [5] vary only the *role label* on a byte-identical erroneous claim and move explicit-correction rates by 23 to 93 percentage points. However, they do so in a single agent without budget matching.

Coordination versus capability. Canedo [2] frames structured specification as a *capability equalizer* whose value falls with model strength. Theoretical [46] and complementary [8] accounts agree. Our enforced condition reproduces that direction only under a scoring rule that drops the trajectories that never finish. Under our pre-registered rule (fixed in writing before the data existed), it reverses for the gemma-4 model and vanishes for the other actors (§5.5).

Prior studies of one trace corpus, and critique uptake. Three studies report on one multi-agent trace corpus on the Omni-MATH benchmark [26, 44, 45], from which our single-agent comparator is also drawn. The closest study separates reviewer *precision* from critique *uptake* [44]. It finds that a pipeline reviewer flags real errors more precisely than broadcast-style peer discussion does. Yet its correct critique far less often changes the next candidate, and uptake improves when the critique is placed in the solver's working context. We ask the organizational counterpart: with the corrective signal held fixed, does the role structure itself make a team more adaptive? None of these studies manipulates the role structure, checks that the specified division of labor is realized, or matches feedback access across conditions. Elsewhere, the failure to revise is almost always measured in a single agent, leaving no organization to ablate.

3 Definitions and Measurement

3.1 What "load-bearing" means here

An organization is specified by a tuple: agents, an interaction order, a message-passing graph, a context-visibility policy, and a *role contract* per agent. A contract asserts that an agent performs some

function (MUST decompose the problem) or that it does not (MUST NOT state a final answer). Clauses of the second kind make the specification a *division* of labor. Because a clause is prose handed to a language model, the *realized* organization is not guaranteed to match it. Nothing records which clauses were honored.

Definition. A component of an organization is **load-bearing** if removing or altering it reproducibly degrades task performance *under matched call and information budgets*.

The budget clause ensures we test organization rather than scale. Removing roles alongside agents, calls or context confounds the evaluation. We apply this definition *per phase*, because a team must first produce an answer and then repair it if it is wrong. The information clause covers every channel through which a signal reaches an agent. In a prompted system, feedback arrives through the same templates that carry the roles. Consequently, a role ablation can change both the roles and the feedback channel. A contrast is matched only when it changes one of them (§4).

3.2 Measuring the realized organization

Functional collapse (primary). The first deliberation cycle (one pass of Planner, Executor and Reviewer) *collapses* if *all three* agents independently assert their own final answers. The pipeline then runs as three solvers in sequence rather than a division of labor. This metric targets the property the diagram asserts, not textual overlap. We measure it on the first cycle so it is not confounded with trajectory length. It is not applicable to the structurally enforced conditions because their schema forbids an answer field.

Exact output duplication (secondary, a lower bound). This occurs when two or more role messages are byte-identical, that is, the same raw completion character for character. It bounds collapse from below (supplement) and is never used to compare actors.

Answer authorship, and computation. We measure whether a Planner authors a final answer. Structural enforcement leaves the Planner no field in which to write one, so this measure serves as the manipulation check. Separately, we track whether a Planner abstains from *computing*, scored as containing no evaluated numeric equality (**P1a**, pre-registered). Because P1a scores the absence of a pattern, it rewards short messages. Therefore, it cannot reliably measure a division of labor, and we use it only as a fidelity check (§4.1).

First pass and recovery. First-pass accuracy grades the first answer submitted to the evaluator. It need not come from the first cycle: for the role-structured team, it may follow internal revision without external feedback. If a trajectory never submits an answer before the budget runs out, it is graded once on its final answer, and that grade is its first pass. *Recovery* is the fraction of *failed* trajectories, those whose first graded answer was wrong, that nonetheless finish correct. Because recovery conditions on a post-treatment variable (whether the first answer failed, which the intervention can change), recovery contrasts are descriptive [32]. We also report the feedback-matched contrast on unconditional final accuracy (§5.2). The verdict-matched analysis (§5.3) is conditional by construction.

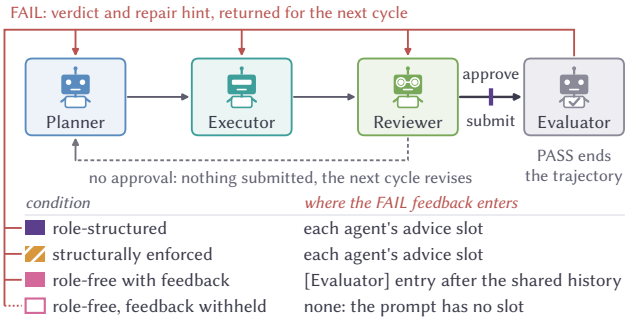


Figure 1: One deliberation cycle and where the feedback enters. A trajectory (one problem's run, at most six cycles) advances one cycle per pass of Planner, Executor and Reviewer. The third agent's approval (the bar marks this gate) is the only route to the evaluator, which knows the reference answer and returns PASS, ending the trajectory, or FAIL with a repair hint; without approval nothing is submitted and the next cycle revises. The key gives where the feedback enters per condition: the advice slot of each role prompt for the role-structured team (Planner, Executor and Reviewer prompts) and the structurally enforced one (the same roles imposed by typed message formats); for the role-free team (one generic prompt for all three agents, with no slot), either nowhere or as an `[Evaluator]` entry in the shared history. A trajectory that never submits is graded once when the budget runs out.

Validation. P1a was hand-adjudicated against a definition frozen *before* the adjudication sheet was opened. It clears a pre-set agreement threshold of 0.80 (supplement).

4 Intervention

We vary organization in both directions from one baseline: we remove it, and we enforce it. All conditions share three agents, one interaction order (Planner → Executor → Reviewer), the message-passing graph, context visibility (except under enforcement, below) and the total call budget. They also use the same verifier and prompt, retry budget, decoding parameters (temperature 0, that is, greedy decoding, and identical `max_tokens`), stopping rule (a PASS ends the trajectory) and grading. Every trajectory in the frozen snapshot carries the identical budget record, so the design tests organization, not scale. Besides the roles, three things differ. After a FAIL, the evaluator returns a repair hint, written with the gold answer (the reference solution) in view and instructed not to reveal it. The role-structured and enforced templates show the hint to all three agents in the next cycle, each through its role's advice slot, the template field reserved for the evaluator's feedback (Figure 1). The role-free template has no such slot, so we report the role-free condition both without and with the feedback. The role-free footer (the closing instruction of the prompt) also asks every agent for an answer, and the role-structured Reviewer carries two clauses the role-free prompt lacks.

Role-structured PER (baseline). Role prompts are as ordinarily written. The Reviewer is told to approve only a complete answer of the right shape. In a cycle that receives a FAIL, it is told to route the work back to the Planner or Executor rather than approve.

Role-free, feedback withheld. All three agents receive one byte-identical prompt, "You are one of three agents collaboratively solving this problem. Continue the work.", followed by the problem, the shared history and the agent's slot number (its position, first to third). A footer asks for the agent's current best answer in `\boxed{}` and a closing `[Agree]` (ready to submit) or `[Continue]`, the conventions the role-structured Executor and Reviewer use. Every clause saying who does what is removed, above all the Planner's MUST NOTs on computing and answering. In every prose condition, the third agent's `[Agree]` is approval (a message with neither tag counts as `[Continue]`), and the latest boxed answer is submitted. Nothing in this template carries the evaluator's verdict or hint.

Role-free with feedback. This condition uses the same role-free prompt, byte for byte, plus the evaluator's verdict and repair hint, the string the role-structured team receives. All three agents see it as an `[Evaluator]` entry after the shared history in the cycle after a FAIL, so it stays visible for one cycle, as the advice slot does. It differs from the feedback-withheld condition only in the feedback.

Structurally enforced. The interface, not the wording, enforces specialization. The Planner emits JSON (a typed output format) against a schema with *no answer field*, so a final answer is unrepresentable. The Executor receives the parsed plan object and the problem, never the Planner's raw text, and emits a derivation and an answer. The Reviewer emits a verdict, a target span and a critique. Its `accept` promotes the Executor's answer verbatim *by reference*, because it has no field in which to *author* one. Each function stays with one agent under the same budget, but the Executor sees less context, and a rejected output can exhaust the regeneration budget (the number of times a malformed output may be regenerated). A *context-restored control* repeats this condition with the shared history restored.

Single-agent reference. A budget-matched single-agent protocol on the same problems guards against multi-agent gains that merely mimic a single capable agent [47]. It comes from a separate, earlier corpus (§4.2). The comparison cuts both ways, and the arms come from separate runs (supplement).

4.1 Instrumentation and pre-registered analyses

An intervention that never engages cannot explain an outcome, so we measure engagement. We log every rejected-and-regenerated output with its reason, count only role-boundary violations in the enforcement rate, and count answer-bearing calls per condition. One logging gap slipped through (§5.1).

All five endpoints (the pre-specified analyses) were fixed in writing and committed before any intervention data existed. The full table, with the outcome for each, is in the supplement. Units are (problem, actor) pairs, and all conditions run the same problems, so every test is paired, with bootstrap intervals that resample whole problems [11]. The pre-registered primary endpoint, P4, asks whether enforcement's effect on accuracy differs by actor. It is null: no pairwise difference-in-differences (enforcement's effect in one actor minus its effect in another) survives Holm's correction for multiple comparisons [20] (smallest adjusted $p = 0.17$). Before correction, the interval for the Llama-3.3 model against gemma-4, +0.040 [+0.001, +0.080], only just excludes zero, and a separate resample gives $p = 0.055$. Only the gpt-oss against gemma-4 contrast had adequate statistical power for an interaction of plausible size.

The P1a manipulation objective also failed. It required enforcement to drive Planner computation-abstention to ≈1.0, but the schema forbids an *answer*, not a computation. It was re-designated to answer authorship. The role-structured versus role-free contrast this paper is organized around was pre-registered as a secondary, exploratory replication of a published null, and splitting it into phases is post hoc. The role-free condition with feedback was added after the freeze (when the dataset and analysis plan were fixed). Its design and primary analysis were committed in writing before any of its data existed, but its results are exploratory. Exclusions were fixed in advance, including the rule that decides §5.5: *unparseable trajectories count as incorrect rather than dropped.*

4.2 Campaign

Task and problems. We use the Omni-MATH benchmark of competition mathematics [14], sampled by a deterministic seeded manifest (a fixed, reproducible list of problem identifiers) so that every prefix of the run is a valid random sample. All conditions run the same problems, so every comparison is paired. A multiple-choice benchmark was ruled out before launch: on a four-option item, producing a different candidate succeeds one time in three by chance, which would inflate recovery.

Actors and scale. Three actor models are served from one pinned vLLM server [28]: gpt-oss-120b [34], gemma-4-31B [16] and Llama-3.3-70B [18]. The primary analysis reads one frozen snapshot of 11,600 trajectories, 83,320 role messages and 17,486 gradings on 1,600 problems sampled uniformly at random from the 4,181 available. The three main conditions run 1,600 problems per cell (one actor in one condition on one domain) for gemma-4 and gpt-oss and 400 for Llama-3.3. The context-restored control covers gemma-4 and gpt-oss at 400 each. The evaluator is gpt-oss-120b in every cell, itself one of the actors under study (§7). The single-agent comparator is *not* part of this campaign; it comes from an earlier, separately collected corpus on the same benchmark, joined by problem identifier. Power simulated from that corpus is high for the paired per-actor main effect (§4.1 for the interaction). An early campaign, stopped when outputs cut off at the token limit were counted as role-boundary rejections, was never pooled (supplement).

The feedback-matched condition. It was run after the freeze (4,748 trajectories) on the same server, problems, budget and evaluator, for all three actors on Omni-MATH and for gemma-4 and gpt-oss on the SciBench benchmark [42]. Its data are manifested separately and never pooled into a frozen cell. The two gemma-4 cells were run a second time, independently. A re-run of gemma-4's role-structured condition on 400 frozen problems shows no detectable drift in final accuracy (0.818 against 0.825 frozen, paired $p = 0.75$; recovery 0.198 against 0.146). Decoding at temperature 0 is not deterministic on a shared server. The two role-free conditions are byte-identical

Table 1: Functional collapse on the Omni-MATH benchmark. Share of first cycles (one pass of Planner, Executor and Reviewer) in which all three agents assert their own final answer, per actor (the model playing all three agents). RS: role-structured (Planner, Executor and Reviewer prompts); RF⁻ and RF: role-free (one generic prompt for all three agents) with the evaluator's feedback withheld or shown. *Adjudicated no division*: the share of a judged sample of first cycles in which a model judge with a fixed rubric finds no division of labor; the judge did not see the grade but could infer the condition. The byte-duplication lower bound, the enforced condition and a sensitivity analysis over answer-marker definitions are in the supplement.

	functional collapse			adjudicated no division	
actor	RS	RF⁻	RF	RS	RF⁻
gemma-4-31B	0.000	**0.976**	**0.974**	0.000	**0.857**
gpt-oss-120b	0.120	**0.846**	**0.883**	0.000	**1.000**
Llama-3.3-70B	0.000	**0.872**	**0.900**	0.000	**1.000**

until the first verdict, yet they agree on gemma-4's first verdict for 1,496 of 1,598 problems, and their first-cycle collapse differs by up to 0.04 (Table 1). We therefore treat a cell as one sample and give the second run, where we have one, in the supplement. Prompts, runner, analysis scripts and data manifests are in the supplementary material.

5 Results

All statistical contrasts are paired at the problem level, with bootstrap intervals clustered by problem. Trajectories that never produce a graded answer count as incorrect, except in the first-pass contrast of §5.1. Significance is the exact McNemar test [31] on discordant pairs (problems that exactly one condition gets right).

5.1 R1. Removing roles changes the organization, not the first answer

We delete the role clauses and keep the agents, interaction order, budget and evaluator; the role-free footer also asks every agent for its current best answer. Functional collapse, the share of first cycles in which every agent asserts its own final answer, rises from at most 0.120 with roles to at least 0.846 without them for all three actors, the gemma-4, gpt-oss and Llama-3.3 models (Table 1). Most of the change comes from the Planner (per-role rates in the supplement). The Executor answers in both conditions, and for two actors the Reviewer states an answer even with roles, plausibly because approving an answer tends to restate it. The Planner seldom answers with roles (at most 0.183) and nearly always does without them, so the division of labor rests on one prohibition, its MUST NOT clause. Because the role-free footer asks for an answer, the absolute level partly reflects that request; the claim concerns the *change*. The ordering holds for every actor under all three answer-marker definitions (the cues that count as asserting an answer; supplement).

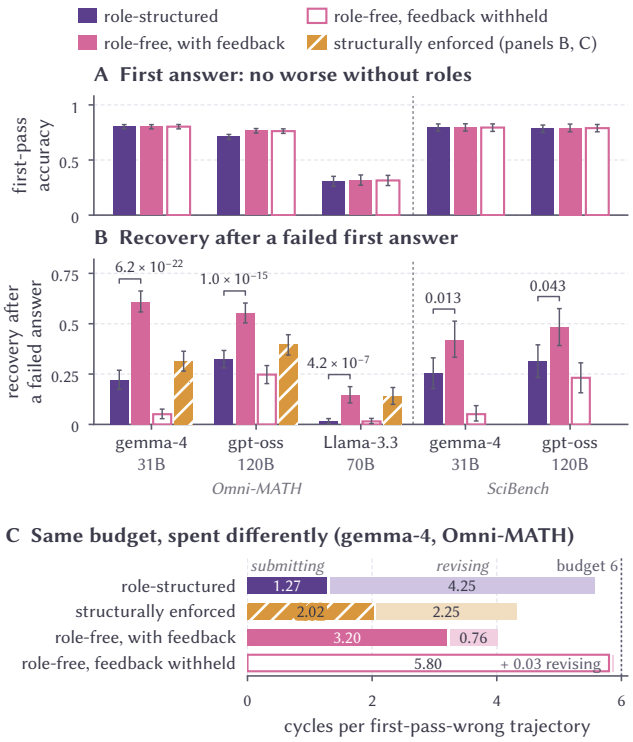


Figure 2: Roles organize the team; given the same feedback, they do not add recovery. Conditions: role-structured (Planner, Executor and Reviewer prompts); role-free (one generic prompt for all three agents) with the evaluator's feedback shown or withheld (hollow); structurally enforced (roles imposed by typed message formats; Omni-MATH only). Actors are the models playing all three agents. (A) First-pass accuracy: whether a team's first submitted answer is correct. (B) Recovery: the share of first-pass-wrong trajectories (runs whose first graded answer was wrong) that finish correct, each condition over its own set; brackets give the exact McNemar p for role-structured against role-free with feedback, paired on problems both first answer wrongly. (C) How gemma-4's first-pass-wrong Omni-MATH trajectories spend the six-cycle budget: cycles ending in a submission (the third agent approved) or a revision (it declined). (A) is over trajectories with a first verdict; in (B) trajectories that never finish count as unrecovered; error bars are bootstrap 95% intervals.

Content duplication and a second opinion. For the gemma-4 and Llama-3.3 models, the role-free Planners write full independent solutions before boxing an answer, and their messages share far more numbers with the Executor's than messages from different problems do, and far more than with roles (supplement). The Executor thus redoes the Planner's computation instead of carrying out a plan. A frontier model judging a sample of first cycles against a frozen rubric agrees with the functional-collapse measure (Table 1), and its repeated judgments almost always agree (supplement). This adjudication is outcome-blind (the judge did not see the grade) but not condition-blind: role words were renamed rather

than equalized across conditions, so a renamed token appears in all 42 role-structured items but in only 3 of 56 role-free ones. The collapse claim does not rest on it.

First-pass accuracy does not follow. The collapse costs no accuracy: on problems graded both with roles and without them (feedback withheld), first-pass accuracy is *identical* for gemma-4 (+0.0000, [−0.0156, +0.0150]), flat for Llama-3.3 and higher without roles for gpt-oss (+0.0503, [+0.0339, +0.0666]; Figure 2A). Because one model plays every agent, a Planner that solves the problem brings no competence the Executor lacks. The gpt-oss model may gain because its answers vary between derivations (§5.2), so extra independent solutions add chances to be right; we did not test this.

A logging defect. Our runner logged each response's `content` field and fell back to its `reasoning` field (the hidden reasoning trace) only when the content was empty. The gpt-oss-120b model often returns a short content string beside a long hidden trace, so most of its role-free derivations (75.7% of messages) are missing from the record, and the flag meant to report this misses most of them (supplement). Agents pass content only, by design and in every condition, so the defect is in the record alone, but no point estimate of gpt-oss's duplication is recoverable. It does not manufacture the collapse: in first cycles with no affected message (106 without roles), role-free collapse is 0.821 and role-structured 0.118.

5.2 R2. Given the same feedback, the role-free team recovers more

What a cycle is. The pipeline runs a fixed grid of six deliberation cycles, three outer rounds of two inner rounds, each one pass of Planner, Executor and Reviewer; Figure 1 shows how a cycle ends in a *submission* or a *revision*.

Recovery and final accuracy. The role-structured team receives the evaluator's feedback, so the like-for-like comparison is with the role-free team that also receives it (Table 2). That team recovers more in all five cells. For gemma-4 on Omni-MATH it recovers 0.609 of its failed trajectories against 0.222 (each team over its own; Figure 2B), and of the 236 problems both first answer wrongly, 89 are recovered only without roles and 4 only with them ($p = 6.2{\times}10^{-22}$). Both teams reach the same first-pass rate and never lose a correct first answer, so the extra recoveries carry straight into final accuracy (0.921 against 0.846). They are genuine revisions: nearly every passing answer differs from the one first rejected, and identical evaluator prompts almost never disagree (supplement).

Leakage and reproducibility. Because the evaluator writes hints with the gold answer in view, a hint could hand over the answer. Hints contain it verbatim in at most 2.3% of failing verdicts in any cell, and dropping every gemma-4 trajectory on the Omni-MATH benchmark that saw one barely moves either recovery rate (supplement); we did not audit partial leakage. A second, independent run of the two gemma-4 feedback-matched cells is close to the first, though the paired test on the SciBench benchmark weakens from $p = 0.013$ to 0.052; we report the first run throughout (supplement).

Why the role effect differs by actor. The other two actors repeat the ordering (Table 2), and the feedback leaves their first-pass accuracy unchanged, as it must: the two role-free conditions are identical until the first verdict. Against the feedback-withheld baseline, the role-structured advantage depends on how much an actor needs feedback to change its answer. It is clear for gemma-4, whose answer rarely moves without feedback (one distinct answer in 84.5% of failed trajectories, against 20.8% for gpt-oss), directional for gpt-oss (0.324 against 0.247; $p = 0.21$), which revises even without feedback, and absent for Llama-3.3 (0.014 against 0.015), whose role-structured team almost never submits and so rarely sees the feedback its prompts could carry.

5.3 R3. Matched on verdicts, the gap closes; roles gate submission

The feedback-withheld baseline. Without the feedback, the role-free team cannot revise. It submits in almost every cycle (Figure 2C), but nothing in its prompts tells the agents that the answer failed, so the next cycle repeats it (§5.2); for gemma-4, 7 of its 16 recoveries are the same answer graded again. Given the verdict and hint, the identical prompts produce a team that revises. The answer moves (a single distinct answer in only 6.6% of failed trajectories), and recovery rises from 0.051 to 0.609; of the 265 problems both first answer wrongly, 139 are recovered only with the feedback and 2 only without it ($p = 7.2 \times 10^{-39}$). For gemma-4, revision requires the feedback rather than the roles.

Matched on verdicts, the gap closes. The role-free team with feedback also receives more of it. Each submission returns a verdict and, on a FAIL, a hint written with the gold answer in view, so every submission is another chance to revise. To compare the teams at equal exposure, a post-hoc analysis takes the problems both first answer wrongly and cuts each role-free trajectory off after as many evaluator verdicts as the role-structured team received on the same problem. No cell then shows a significant difference (Table 2; $p \geq 0.48$; Llama-3.3's cell has five events). Pooled and stratified by cell, the difference is +0.009 in favor of roles (95% paired bootstrap interval −0.014 to +0.033). The match is coarse: a role-free trajectory cut at a single verdict, a FAIL, cannot recover, so wherever the role-structured team received one verdict the pair ties at zero by construction, as in most of gemma-4's pairs. Restricted to problems with at least two such verdicts, the difference is +0.018 (−0.029 to +0.065); recoding the scoring defect of §7 gives +0.029 (+0.004 to +0.054), and repeating the comparison against the post-freeze role-structured re-run gives the same pattern (supplement). No variant puts the role-free team significantly ahead verdict for verdict; the only significant variant favors roles, by a small margin. Given the same feedback, the two teams use it about equally well; the role-free team recovers more because it asks for more.

What roles do instead: a gate on submission. The gap in verdicts comes from the role-structured Reviewer. For gemma-4 that team submits 1.27 times per failed trajectory, against 3.20 without roles (Figure 2C). Much of the withholding happens before any feedback exists: 53% of the Reviewer's declines come before the first submission, and 84 of the 316 failed trajectories never submit, so they are graded once at the end and never see the feedback. The clause that forbids approval right after a FAIL covers only 19% of the declines; in later cycles where approval is allowed, the Reviewer still declines in 75% of cycles, against 4% for the role-free team's third agent. On

Table 2: The feedback-matched contrast in every cell (one actor, the model playing all three agents, on one benchmark; n problems). RS: role-structured (Planner, Executor and Reviewer prompts); RF: role-free (one generic prompt for all three agents) with the evaluator's feedback shown; RF$^-$: role-free with it withheld. A trajectory (one problem's run) is first-pass wrong when its first submitted answer is graded wrong. *Recovery*: share of first-pass-wrong trajectories that finish correct, each condition over its own set. *Recovered only by*: on the n problems both RS and RF first answer wrongly, those recovered by one condition and not the other, with the exact McNemar p for the two counts. *Verdict-matched*: the same paired recovery with each RF trajectory cut off after as many evaluator verdicts (PASS or FAIL decisions) as RS received on that problem, so both get the same number of verdicts and hints. *Final accuracy*: correct at the end, over all problems, paired; never-graded trajectories count as incorrect. *Submissions*: answers sent to the evaluator per first-pass-wrong trajectory. *RS never submits*: RS first-pass-wrong trajectories with no submission in six cycles, graded once at the end.

	recovery			recovered only by (paired)				verdict-matched			final accuracy			submissions		RS never
actor, domain (n)	RS	RF	RF$^-$	n	RS	RF	p	RS	RF	p	RS	RF	p	RS	RF	submits
gemma-4, Omni-MATH (1,600)	0.222	0.609	0.051	236	4	89	6.2×10^{-22}	0.165	0.153	0.69	0.846	0.921	1.7×10^{-24}	1.27	3.20	84/316
gpt-oss, Omni-MATH (1,600)	0.324	0.552	0.247	319	17	101	1.0×10^{-15}	0.229	0.216	0.72	0.803	0.894	2.7×10^{-28}	2.10	3.53	51/463
Llama-3.3, Omni-MATH (400)	0.014	0.147	0.015	250	1	26	4.2×10^{-7}	0.012	0.008	1.0	0.315	0.415	1.6×10^{-7}	0.32	2.71	205/276
gemma-4, SciBench (574)	0.254	0.419	0.051	100	7	21	0.013	0.230	0.190	0.48	0.847	0.880	0.0054	1.95	3.62	3/118
gpt-oss, SciBench (574)	0.315	0.483	0.231	93	7	18	0.043	0.215	0.247	0.68	0.852	0.892	1.9×10^{-4}	2.68	3.95	1/124

Omni-MATH the clause covers at most 37% of the declines for any actor, so there the gate reflects the Reviewer's disposition rather than the letter of its prompt, plausibly because an agent told to critique finds something to criticize; on SciBench the clause covers more (supplement). Higher recoveries per later verdict with roles (0.41 against 0.28 for gemma-4) can look like precision, but that ratio compares different trajectories (supplement).

Removing the gate alone. If the gate causes the gap, removing it with the role prompts untouched should close the gap. A direct, exploratory test keeps the role-structured prompts byte for byte but submits the team's answer in every cycle, whatever the Reviewer decides. We ran it once, for gemma-4 on the 400 Omni-MATH problems of the post-freeze re-run (supplement). The team then draws far more verdicts (4.20 against 1.44 per failed trajectory), and recovery rises from 0.198 to 0.613, as high as the role-free team's 0.549 on the same problems (paired, 26 against 2, $p = 3.0 \times 10^{-6}$; against the role-free team, 7 against 7). First-pass accuracy does not move, so the Reviewer's declines before any feedback were not buying a better first answer either. With the role contract intact, removing the gate removed the gap.

5.4 R4. The same ordering in a second domain

The SciBench benchmark's complete text-only slice of 574 free-response college science problems, frozen separately, tests whether the pattern belongs to the organization or to competition mathematics. The role-free prompt is byte-identical across domains; the role-structured and evaluator prompts adapt only their domain wording (supplement). For both actors run there, the gemma-4 and gpt-oss models, the ordering returns (Table 2): first-pass accuracy is flat, recovery is highest with feedback and no roles, and final accuracy is higher without roles. The recovery contrast is weaker, consistent with a looser gate: the role-structured team almost always submits at least once (all but 3 and 1 of its failed trajectories), so more of the feedback reaches it, and, as on Omni-MATH, the contrast vanishes when both teams are credited with the same number of verdicts. Unlike on Omni-MATH, gemma-4's role-structured answer does not lock here, possibly because of the looser gate (supplement).

5.5 R5. Structural enforcement shifts the allocation, and introduces brittleness

Enforced and role-structured prompts carry the same advice slot, so this contrast is matched on feedback access. Enforcement replaces the behavioral request with a constraint: the Planner's final answer becomes unrepresentable. The manipulation check passes: the Planner asserts a final answer in 0.000 of enforced first cycles for all three actors, against at least 0.889 without roles. Enforcement does not change what the Planner *computes*, so the adjudication still finds no functional division in 0.071 to 0.188 of enforced first cycles: an agent can be structurally stopped from answering without being stopped from doing the work. It does loosen the gate: the enforced team submits more often for every actor and, with more hints arriving, unlocks the answer for gemma-4 and Llama-3.3 (supplement).

Recovery rises most where the gate was tightest. Llama-3.3's role-structured team almost never submits, and under enforcement its recovery rises about tenfold, from 0.014 to 0.139 ($p = 3.8\times10^{-6}$), close to the role-free team's 0.147. For gemma-4 and gpt-oss the direction is the same ($p = 0.30$ and 0.11) but not resolvable against attrition: the 150 enforced trajectories that died after an incorrect first verdict count as unrecovered, as the pre-registration requires.

Improved revisability does not become end-to-end accuracy, because enforcement is brittle. A malformed or boundary-violating output must be regenerated, and when the regeneration budget runs out the trajectory dies: 8.0%, 9.9% and 17.0% of enforced trajectories never finish, against at most 2.5% in any other condition, and the weakest actor breaks the schema most often (supplement). Under the pre-registered rule, which counts these trajectories as incorrect, enforcement changes accuracy by −0.0225, −0.0050 and +0.0175 for gemma-4, gpt-oss and Llama-3.3: one significant negative and two nulls. Dropping them instead gives gains for all three actors, all significant and ordered by actor weakness, matching the direction reported for the capability equalizer [2]. That reading is

survivorship bias, since it scores only the trajectories that finished. For gemma-4, part of the brittleness is lost context: restoring the shared history at fixed enforcement raises its pre-registered accuracy (+0.0450, $p = 0.0079$), mostly through fewer trajectories dying, since as graded the change is not significant; gpt-oss does not gain (supplement).

6 Discussion

Function of roles: gating submission vs. driving revision. Producing a first answer is a *generation* problem. Having three agents reach the same place by three routes costs nothing but tokens, and first-pass accuracy is nearly indifferent to the division of labor. After a failure, the team must produce something unlike the answer that just failed. Except for the gpt-oss model, teams rarely do so unless told that the candidate failed. Given that knowledge, the role contract adds little capacity to revise. When matched on the number of verdicts, the two teams differ little. The role contract primarily decides *when* the team asks for evaluation. The role-structured Reviewer withholds approval until it is satisfied, so the team draws fewer verdicts and sometimes none at all. Overriding the Reviewer closed the gap for the gemma-4 model. Under a ground-truth evaluator and a fixed cycle budget, fewer verdicts mean fewer recoveries. Where verification is costly, noisy, or unavailable, a team that asks less often could be the better design; this experiment cannot tell.

Practical implications for multi-agent system design. First, if a cheap and reliable verifier is available, a Reviewer role that withholds submission can cost recoveries. It is better to let the team submit and gate on the verifier rather than on an internal critic. Second, regardless of the role structure, the verifier's feedback must be routed to every agent that can act on it. In our pipeline, the teams of the gemma-4 and Llama-3.3 models without a feedback slot almost never recovered, whereas the same prompts recovered far more often once the feedback was added.

Methodological pitfalls: the necessity of information audits. In a prompted multi-agent system, feedback, tool outputs and verifier verdicts reach the agents through slots in the same templates that carry the role instructions, so rewriting those templates can silently remove a channel. Nothing in the budget record, call counts or accuracy metrics reports the absence. A role ablation therefore needs an information audit alongside the budget audit: the runtime inputs each template consumes must be documented, and a contrast is matched only when those input sets are identical. Our role-structured and feedback-withheld conditions differ in one such input, the feedback itself.

Reassessing the value of role diagrams. Precise reviewing does not necessarily mean the critique is adopted [44]. Similarly, a clean division of labor does not guarantee that a team adapts. What matters is whether corrective information changes the next action taken by the system. Task-outcome evaluation alone cannot test this because an aggregate score averages stages where the organization is idle with stages where it does all its work. We recommend two additions to standard evaluations: report performance conditioned on a failed first attempt, and measure the realized organization rather than assume the specified one.

7 Limitations

Evaluation paradigm and oracle-gated recovery. The recovery loop in our experiments is gated by an oracle. The evaluator triggering retries sees the ground truth, so every reported recovery rests on a ground-truth-informed failure signal rather than unaided self-correction. Stopping at the correct answer also hides revisions that would have turned a correct answer into a wrong one. An evaluator that can be queried multiple times favors the team that queries it most. As shown in §5.3, when matched on the number of verdicts, the role-free advantage disappears.

Scope, provenance, and experimental disclosures. We test one PER organization, with an evaluator that is itself one of the models under study. While the ordering returns across a second domain of college science problems, the findings are limited to text-based reasoning tasks. The feedback-matched condition and the forced-submission run were added after the freeze and are outside the pre-registration. The forced-submission run covers only one actor, one domain, and a single run, and it removes the entire gate rather than only the clause forbidding approval after a failure. The feedback-matched condition also differs in feedback presentation: role-structured agents receive feedback inside role-specific instructions, whereas role-free agents view it as a bare `[Evaluator]` entry. Finally, the context-restored control is only a *partial* control due to one-sided attrition (§5.5), and our functional measure only detects whether every agent asserted an answer, not whether their reasoning was identical.

A scoring defect. The automated runner graded the last *submitted* answer but recorded the last *held* answer. For the gemma-4 model on the Omni-MATH benchmark, the two disagree on 17% of role-structured first-pass-wrong trajectories, and on more in some other cells (per-cell rates in the supplement). Recoding the affected trajectories narrows the unadjusted recovery gap and shifts the pooled verdict-matched difference to +0.029 [+0.004, +0.054], which significantly favors the role-structured team (§5.3). The primary analysis keeps the scoring rule that was fixed before the data were collected.

8 Conclusion

Multi-agent roles organize a team into a structured workflow. Deleting these roles destroyed the intended division of labor across all tested models, but first-pass accuracy did not fall. Roles only appeared load-bearing for repairing rejected answers when compared against a role-free team that never received the evaluator's feedback. When both teams received the identical feedback string, the role-free team recovered more trajectories across every tested configuration. When matched on the number of evaluator verdicts, this advantage disappeared.

These findings suggest that roles change little about how a team uses corrective feedback but substantially alter how often the team asks for it. Structure is not adaptability. Evaluating agent organization therefore requires checking both whether the specified division of labor is realized and whether corrective information reaches the team and changes its next actions.

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